

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/22: Syllabus item 19, the controlling question, and the plural

SYLLABUS ITEM 19, PRINTED VERBATIM:

"Schools of Vedanta : Brahman; Isvara; Atman; Jiva; Jagat; Maya; Avida; Adhyasa; Moksa; Aprthaksiddhi; Pancavidhabheda."

normalised: ultimate reality (brahman) · the Lord (īśvara) · true self (ātman) ·

individual self (jiva) · world (jagat) · indescribable illusion (māyā) ·

ignorance (avidyā, printed "Avida") · superimposition (adhyāsa) · liberation (mokṣa) ·

inseparable dependence (aprthaksiddhi) · fivefold difference (pañcavidhabheda)

THE PLURAL IS THE EXAMINATION: this is the ONLY Paper I clause beginning with "Schools". Not one of the eleven terms has a single Vedāntic meaning.

CONTROLLING QUESTION is the relation of the FINITE to the ABSOLUTE
IDENTITY, QUALIFICATION, or DIFFERENCE?

+---- THE THUMB-RULE -----+
| every printed term must be answered in THREE-SCHOOL COMPARATIVE MODE, even |
| when the question names only one school, because a shared term's meaning is |
| fixed only by contrast |
+-----+

CORPUS SIGNAL 20 primary-owned parts of 112 in the 2018-2025 corpus, second
only to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika. Owned in EVERY year of the window:
2018×3 · 2019×1 · 2020×3 · 2021×3 · 2022×3 · 2023×3 · 2024×1 ·
2025×3

SUPPORTING ONLY .. 2018 Q7(b) real transformation (owner: Sāṃkhya) ·
2018 Q8(a) self-luminosity and intrinsic validity (owner: Mīmāṃsā)

+-----+
| ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE |
| Vedānta is not one doctrine but three answers to one question, and every |
| printed syllabus term is that same fork applied to a different object. |
+-----+

! TRAP 1: do not reduce "Vedānta" to Advaita; two-thirds of the owned questions
require Rāmānuja, Madhva or a wider school.

! TRAP 2: do not treat the eleven terms as eleven topics; they are one dispute
applied eleven times.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/22: The threefold canon and the six commentarial schools

THE THREEFOLD CANON (prasthāna-trayī)

principal Upaniṣads + Bhagavad Gītā + Brahma Sūtra of Bādarāyaṇa
 revealed foundation remembered reasoned systematization
 (śruti-prasthāna) synthesis (nyāya-prasthāna)
 (smṛti-prasthāna)

the Sūtra is COMPACT: aphorisms, NOT finished doctrine

=> the common site of COMPETING COMMENTARIES rather than a settlement of them

SCHOOL	TEACHER / TEXT	ROOT RELATION
non-dualism (advaita)	Śaṅkara, Brahma-sūtra-bhāṣya + Upaniṣad and Gītā comms.	identity; difference is ignorance- conditioned
qualified non-dualism (viśiṣṭādvaita)	Rāmānuja, Śrī-bhāṣya, Vedārthasaṅgraha, Gītā comm.	real selves/world inseparably qualify
dualism (dvaita)	Madhva, Brahma-sūtra-bhāṣya, Anuvyākhyāna, Gītā comm.	really different; only God independent
dualistic non-dualism (dvaitādvaita)	Nimbārka, Vedānta-pārijāta- saurabha	difference AND non- difference both real
pure non-dualism (śuddhādvaita)	Vallabha, Aṇubhāṣya	world is a REAL UNCHANGED manifest.
inconceivable difference- non-difference (acintyabhedābheda)	Caitanya tradition; Rūpa, Jīva and Baladeva Gosvāmin	real difference and non-difference by divine powers

OWNERSHIP FIREWALL

HELD HERE Brahman-centred Upaniṣadic interpretation · accomplished reality
 (siddha-vastu) as independently disclosive · the eleven terms

OWNED THERE ... earlier Mīmāṃsā: injunction (vidhi), duty, authorless verbal
 authority, ritual interpretation, act-to-be-done (kārya)

=> the boundary is itself examinable: can Vedic sentences reveal a NON-ACTIONAL
 accomplished reality?

PRICE PAID BY EACH BRANCH (the comparative spine in one strip)

identity world, individuality, ethics and devotion become lower-order

qualification .. real modes press on divine simplicity and changelessness

difference non-dual Upaniṣadic sentences become harder to read; hierarchy

! TRAP: "the schools differ about scripture" is FALSE and unrewarded. They agree
 about scripture and differ about its interpretation.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/22: Ultimate reality – two definitions and the attributes fork

ULTIMATE REALITY (brahman) – DEFINED TWICE

ESSENTIAL (svarūpa-lakṣaṇa)	RELATIONAL (taṭastha-lakṣaṇa)
being-consciousness-bliss	janmādyasya yataḥ – that from which origin,
(sat-cit-ānanda)	sustenance and dissolution proceed
= WHAT IT IS in itself	= WHY it is called the ground of the world

"Does the absolute HAVE determinate attributes?"

NO – qualityless (nirguṇa)	YES – qualified (saguṇa)
ADVAITA	
* sole ULTIMATELY REAL (pāramārthika)	VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA – Rāmānuja
* nirguṇa ≠ blankness; it means FREE OF LIMITING, relational, empirical, objectifiable attributes	* saguṇa in the HIGHEST sense: ananta-kalyāṇa-guṇa-viśiṣṭa endowed with infinite auspicious qualities
* sat-cit-ānanda = ESSENCE, not a list of accidental predicates	* qualities are PERFECTIONS, not limiting adjuncts
* creatorhood, omniscience, lordship, moral governance => belong to the LORD (īśvara) at the EMPIRICAL level	* identified with Viṣṇu-Nārāyaṇa
	* NO qualityless level above him
	DVAITA – Madhva
	* personal Viṣṇu, perfect infinite attributes
	* alone INDEPENDENT (svatantra); selves and world DEPENDENT (paratantra)
	* difference itself is ULTIMATE – not absorbed into qualified unity

RĀMĀNUJA'S CRITIQUE OF THE QUALITYLESS ABSOLUTE – asked 2023 Q6(a), 20 marks

an entity WITHOUT attributes cannot be known

if utterly indeterminate => cannot be the referent of scriptural description

if no internal intelligibility => cannot cause a richly qualified world

scriptural passages that NEGATE DEFECTS do not negate ALL qualities

=> Śaṅkara's absolute becomes unknowable emptiness OR an abstraction too thin to ground religion, devotion, causality or ethics

ADVAITA'S REPLY: it is not known as an OBJECT with predicates; it is SELF-REVEALED as the ground of all knowing. Denying limiting predicates ≠ denying nature.

CONSEQUENCE CASCADE (why this panel governs all the others)

nirguṇa read => world becomes appearance · the Lord becomes lower truth ·

liberation becomes identity-recognition · scripture finally sublatale

saguṇa read => world and devotion become central · liberation becomes communion or

service · scripture stays final

! TRAP 1: "Brahman has no nature at all" destroys the answer at the outset.

! TRAP 2: "Rāmānuja accepts both nirguṇa and saguṇa Brahman" inverts his whole critique.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/22: Efficient and material causality across the schools

QUESTION: is ultimate reality the world's MATERIAL cause as well as its EFFICIENT cause? – asked 2025 Q6(b), 15 marks, "with suitable examples"

DEFINITIONS

efficient cause (nimitta-kāraṇa) the intelligent agency that brings about
material cause (upādāna-kāraṇa) that OUT OF WHICH the effect is constituted

ADVAITA -----

premise nothing exists independently of ultimate reality
therefore .. there is NO SECOND MATERIAL out of which the world is made
so it is BOTH the intelligence behind the world AND the material basis
of its APPEARANCE
image the SPIDER spinning the web out of itself
qualified by APPARENT TRANSFORMATION (vivarta): it does NOT really become the
world; the world is an appearance dependent on it
image the ROPE and the SNAKE – substrate supports what it never becomes
net "material cause" = SUBSTRATE, not transformed stuff

VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA -----

both causes, but causation is REAL
subtle conscious (cit) and non-conscious (acit) modes => gross manifestation
ultimate reality remains their controlling SUBSTANTIVE WHOLE
the transformation belongs to it THROUGH the real transformation of the
NON-CONSCIOUS mode – NOT through corruption of God's auspicious essence
cause-state = SUBTLE · effect-state = GROSS

DVAITA -----

God = EFFICIENT cause (nimitta-kāraṇa) ONLY
primordial matter (prakṛti) = REAL DEPENDENT material cause, energised and
governed by God
dependence on God is universal – YET God, souls and matter remain really and
eternally different
! therefore "brahman is both efficient and material cause" is TRUE of Advaita and
Viśiṣṭādvaita IN DIFFERENT SENSES, and FALSE of Dvaita

RIVAL SCHOOLS OUTSIDE VEDĀNTA – one-line contrast bank

Sāṃkhya prakṛti is material cause; NO efficient creator-God
Nyāya God is primarily EFFICIENT; eternal atoms are MATERIAL
formula Sāṃkhya splits material causality from intelligence; Nyāya splits
efficient from material causality; Vedānta REUNITES both

! TRAP: "all Vedānta schools hold Brahman is both causes" – Madhva denies it
explicitly.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/22: Six means of valid knowledge and the primacy of testimony

ADVAITA'S SIX INSTRUMENTS (following the Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā list)

perception (pratyakṣa)	immediate cognition through sense- contact with a PRESENT object	"this pot is blue"
inference (anumāna)	unperceived fact via a perceived mark (liṅga) + concomitance (vyāpti)	smoke on the hill => fire
comparison (upamāna)	fresh cognition of an ABSENT familiar object's similarity	gavaya seen => the remembered cow is like
verbal testimony (śabda)	valid cognition from reliable words, supremely the AUTHORLESS (apauruṣeya) Veda	the great sentence teaches self-absolute identity
postulation (arthāpatti)	presumption of an unseen fact to reconcile incompatible known facts	fat Devadatta does not eat by day => eats at night
non-apprehension (anupalabdhī)	cognition of ABSENCE through non- perception under proper conditions	"there is no pot on the floor"

EVERY instrument presupposes the triad KNOWER - MEANS - KNOWN
(pramātṛ - pramāṇa - prameya)

that triad presupposes DUALITY => all six work ONLY at the EMPIRICAL level
(vyāvahārika); at the ULTIMATE level (pāramārthika) there is no second object,
no separate knower, no instrument – the whole apparatus is sublated

REFLEXIVE PUZZLE → if all instruments are only empirically valid, how does
testimony establish the ULTIMATE truth?

REPLY → scripture REMOVES IGNORANCE and then loses operative relevance
ALONG WITH the ignorance it removed

IMAGES → the CLEARING-NUT (kataka) that settles the mud and settles with
it · the STICK that stirs the pyre and is consumed in it

=> scripture is NOT an eternal second reality alongside the absolute; it is the
EMPIRICAL LADDER by which the non-empirical truth is recognised

WHY NOT THE OTHER FIVE?

perception the absolute is qualityless, non-objectifiable, not sensed

inference no perceived instance, no mark uniquely co-present; and an
inferred absolute becomes an inferred OBJECT (prameya)

comparison, postulation, non-apprehension derivative / empirically
parasitic: similarity, presumption and absence all operate
INSIDE the field of knowable objects

=> Śaṅkara: the absolute is ŚĀSTRA-YONI / ŚĀSTRA-PRAMĀṆAKA – known through scripture

=> FOUR GREAT SENTENCES: tat tvam asi · ahaṃ brahmāsmi · prajñānaṃ brahma ·
ayam ātmā brahma

FAULT-LINE WITH EARLIER MĪMĀMSĀ

Mīmāṃsā Vedic authority is primarily authority for INJUNCTION (vidhi) about
duty; statements of fact are subordinate to ritual action

Advaita Upaniṣadic statements about ACCOMPLISHED REALITY (siddha-vastu) are
independently and supremely valid; knowledge (jñāna) is NOT an act
to be performed (kārya)

OBJ if the Veda is for action, how can a sentence stating identity
produce liberation?

REPLY bondage is IGNORANCE, not absence of ritual; therefore the direct
remover must be KNOWLEDGE

=> the divide is not ritual-versus-metaphysics but whether Vedic sentences can
independently reveal a NON-ACTIONAL accomplished reality

! TRAP: "Advaita rejects perception and inference" – it denies ULTIMACY, not
empirical validity.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/22: Three-school contrast on the means of knowledge

SCHOOL	COUNT	ACCEPTED INSTRUMENTS	CONSEQUENCE
ADVAITA	6	perception · inference · comparison · testimony · postulation · non-apprehension	wide epistemology kept EMPIRICALLY, but only testimony reveals the non-objective absolute, and is then SUBLATED
VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA	3	perception · inference · testimony (rest reduced to these)	ACCEPTS indeterminate perception (nirvikalpaka) but REDEFINES it: the FIRST cognition of an individual already apprehended with its configuration (saṁsthāna) determinate (savikalpaka) = second cognition that recognises the GENERIC character as recurrent REJECTS cognition of a WHOLLY QUALIFIERLESS (nirviśeṣa) object: sarvaṁ vijñānaṁ saviśeṣam => a qualityless absolute is NOT establishable
DVAITA	3	perception · inference · scriptural tradition (āgama); special weight to scripture, the kevala-pramāṇa / anu-pramāṇa distinction, and the WITNESS (sākṣin) as ultimate internal validator	realist theism: the independent ultimate standard of truth is separated from dependent instruments; expositions of that distinction VARY

COMPARATIVE INSIGHT

a school's instrument-count TRACKS its metaphysics:

Advaita needs testimony to disclose a NON-OBJECTIVE absolute

Viśiṣṭādvaita's qualified realism requires ALL cognition to be of the qualified

Dvaita's realist theism requires instruments that SECURE REAL DIFFERENCE

! TRAP 1: "Rāmānuja denies nirvikalpaka perception" misstates a REDEFINITION as a rejection.

! TRAP 2: Madhva's witness (sākṣin) is NOT Advaita's witness (sākṣi) – same word, opposed metaphysics: for Madhva it VALIDATES real difference.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/22: The Lord – three placements and Rāmānuja's critique

ADVAITA the Lord = ultimate reality CONDITIONED BY illusion
(māyā-upahita brahman / māyā-viśiṣṭa brahman)
omniscient · omnipotent · moral governor · creator of the empirical
world · FULLY REAL at the empirical level (vyāvahārika)
YET sublated into the qualityless absolute at the ultimate level
=> theism is NEITHER false in a crude sense NOR final in the last

VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA .. the Lord IS ultimate reality – supreme personal Viṣṇu-Nārāyaṇa
no qualityless level above him · qualities REAL and ETERNAL
IMMANENT because world and souls are his BODY
TRANSCENDENT because he EXCEEDS them

DVAITA Viṣṇu absolutely supreme, ALONE independent and self-sufficient
all selves and the world depend on him ontologically, morally,
soteriologically · difference NEVER erased by liberation

RĀMĀNUJA'S CRITIQUE OF ADVAITA'S LORD – the second half of 2023 Q6(a)
if the Lord belongs ONLY to the empirical level => devotion becomes MERELY
PREPARATORY · scriptural descriptions of God become LOWER TRUTH · religious life
is STRUCTURALLY SUBORDINATED to non-personal absolutism
=> this hollows out devotion and makes scriptural theism PROVISIONAL

THE 2022 HIERARCHY – Q8(a), 20 marks

witness (sākṣī) pure witnessing consciousness · unaffected · immediate ·
non-objectifiable – CLOSEST to the ultimate standpoint

individual (jīva) ... consciousness reflected/limited by ignorance – empirical
BONDAGE

the Lord (īśvara) ... consciousness conditioned by illusion – empirical COSMIC
ORDER

=> NOT three substances but ONE consciousness under THREE DESCRIPTIONS
=> the printed verse "Brahma satyaṃ jagan-mithyā, jīvo brahmaiva nāparaḥ" is a
TRADITIONAL ADVAITA SUMMARY, not one of the four Upaniṣadic great sentences

! TRAP: "Advaita denies God" ignores that the Lord is FULLY REAL at the empirical
level; only ULTIMACY is denied.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/22: Original-reflection, and the three models of individuation

ORIGINAL-REFLECTION MODEL (bimba-pratibimba-vāda) – asked 2025 Q8(a), 20 marks

ORIGINAL (bimba) = pure consciousness / ultimate reality

|

reflected in v a conditioning medium (internal organ under ignorance)

REFLECTION (pratibimba) = the empirical self

* the original is UNAFFECTED by defect, motion or multiplicity in the media,
as ONE FACE is unchanged though many mirrors – cracked, tilted, moving –
yield differently conditioned images

* SOME later formulations: reflection in TOTAL COSMIC appearance = the Lord;
reflections in INDIVIDUAL ignorance / internal organs = the selves

? OTHER formulations make the Lord the ORIGINAL relative to the self, or
prefer LIMITATION or SEMBLANCE models instead

! do NOT write that the Lord is simultaneously "the original" and
"consciousness reflected in illusion" WITHOUT NAMING the relative or later
model being used; these are LATER explanatory alternatives, not one uniform
proposition attributable without qualification to Śaṅkara

SOTERIOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE – the half of the 2025 question most answers miss

the reflected image has only DERIVATIVE reality

=> when ignorance is removed the finite self is known NEVER to have possessed
independent reality apart from original consciousness

=> liberation = RECOGNITION of non-difference, NOT movement, merging or the
destruction of one substance by another

=> this is why liberation can be ATTAINMENT OF WHAT IS ALREADY ATTAINED
(prāptasya prāptiḥ) and why LIBERATION WHILE LIVING (jīvanmukti) is possible

! LIMIT: a formless original, a formless medium and a non-dual reality make
LITERAL reflection impossible; reflection also normally needs a spatial gap.
Use the model for SUGGESTIVE value, not optical physics.

! Madhva uses the SAME metaphor for the OPPOSITE conclusion – that the dependent
image is REALLY DIFFERENT from its original – which shows how far the metaphor
under-determines the metaphysics.

THREE MODELS OF ONE PROBLEM

limitation (avaccheda-vāda) one space appearing as pot-space (ghaṭākāśa);

emphasis on DELIMITATION

associated with VĀCASPATI MIŚRA

reflection (pratibimba-vāda) consciousness reflected in ignorance;

emphasis on DERIVATIVE APPEARANCE and

phenomenological vividness

associated with PADMAPĀDA and the VIVARAṆA line

semblance (ābhāsa-vāda) the self is a mere SEMBLANCE (ābhāsa);

emphasis on ONTOLOGICAL THINNESS

COMMON CONCLUSION: individuality LACKS ULTIMATE REALITY

! TRAP: swapping the names – limitation is Vācaspati Miśra with pot-space,
reflection is Padmapāda with the mirrored face.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/22: The true self, the witness, and the three states

THE STATE-ANALYSIS ARGUMENT (Advaita)

waking (jāgrat) an EXTERNAL object-world is presented
dream (svapna) INTERNALLY generated objects are presented
deep sleep (suṣupti) NO manifest subject-object cognition

|
report on waking: "I slept peacefully; I knew nothing"

=> presupposes CONTINUITY through deep sleep

=> supports a WITNESS not identical with any particular mental mode

|
the FOURTH standpoint (turiya) is NOT a fourth episode after the three;

it is the non-dual consciousness that UNDERLIES and ILLUMINES all three

|
! HONEST QUALIFICATION: this is an argument WITHIN Advaita, not a neutral proof.
Rāmānuja and Nyāya retain an ENDURING SELF while REJECTING its identity with
the non-dual absolute. The argument establishes an enduring witness more
securely than it establishes identity.

WITNESS-CONSCIOUSNESS (sākṣī) – WHAT IT IS AND IS NOT

+ illumines all mental states, never altered by them

+ pleasure, pain, doubt, memory, desire are WITNESSED, not essential to it

+ not a passive blank but the CONDITION for all experience

+ self-luminous (svayaṃ-prakāśa): manifestation belongs to consciousness as its
very nature

- NOT one more knower sitting inside the person

=> Advaita's elegant split: CHANGING PSYCHOLOGY vs CHANGELESS CONSCIOUSNESS

=> episodic cognitions, objects and the empirical knower remain INSIDE the
subject-object structure

THREE SETTLEMENTS OF ONE ENDURING SELF

Advaita	pure consciousness	IDENTICAL in essence
Viśiṣṭādvaita	real eternal conscious self, ATOMIC (aṇu)	INSEPARABLE MODE, not identical
Dvaita	real eternal dependent self	ETERNALLY DIFFERENT

RĀMĀNUJA'S MECHANISM – how an ATOMIC self knows a WIDE world

substantive knower = ATOMIC (aṇu), self-luminous

ATTRIBUTIVE CONSCIOUSNESS (dharma-bhūta-jñāna) = its quality, which REVEALS
objects · CONTRACTS under karmic obstruction · EXPANDS without obstruction in
liberation

=> atomic size does NOT confine cognitive range

in deep sleep the self PERSISTS, but object-manifesting cognition is UNEXPRESSED
because no object is presented

WHY THIS DECIDES EVERYTHING DOWNSTREAM

self IS the absolute liberation = RECOGNITION

self is a MODE of it liberation = COMMUNION

self is permanently DIFFERENT ... liberation = ETERNAL SERVICE

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/22: The individual self – three non-dual models, two realist rivals

MARK THIS FIRST

true self (ātman) the self in its ESSENTIAL metaphysical nature
individual (jīva) the EMBODIED empirical individual in bondage, agency and
transmigration
=> many answers improve immediately just by stating this distinction

ADVAITA – three models, one conclusion (see Panel 8 for the images)

limitation the absolute appears as individual when DELIMITED by ignorance
or internal adjuncts; NOT a real fragment – apparent limitation
alone produces plurality
reflection the individual is the REFLECTION of consciousness in ignorance;
explains dependence AND phenomenological individuality
semblance the individual is a MERE SEMBLANCE; pushes derivative status
further than reflection
=> naming all three shows INTERNAL PLURALITY without losing the shared conclusion

VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA – real conscious mode

a REAL conscious MODE (prakāra) of ultimate reality
NEITHER an illusion NOR a detached independent substance
body-soul analogy (śarīra-śarīrī): depends entirely on God for EXISTENCE, SUPPORT
and ACTIVITY
! "body" does NOT mean gross physical body; it means THAT WHICH IS CONTROLLED,
SUSTAINED AND USED by an indwelling self

DVAITA – real distinct dependent substance

never reducible to God • never a mere mode • never illusory
difference AMONG individuals is ALSO real
taxonomy: eternally free (nitya) • liberated (mukta) • bound (baddha)
bound souls further described as liberation-eligible (mukti-yogya) • eternal
transmigrators (nitya-saṃsārin) • darkness-eligible (tamo-yogya)
! a REAL Madhva doctrine, but NOT needed in every fivefold-difference answer.
Use it where hierarchy, grace or differentiated liberation is relevant, and
EVALUATE its severe ethical implications rather than reporting predestination
casually.

COMPACT STATEMENT BANK – use verbatim

Advaita the individual is the absolute APPEARING FINITE through ignorance
Viśiṣṭādvaita ... the individual is a REAL CONSCIOUS MODE of the absolute
Dvaita the individual is a REAL DEPENDENT SELF ETERNALLY DIFFERENT
from God

PYQ ANCHORS: 2021 Q8(c) Madhva's individual and world • 2022 Q8(a) the ontological
status of Lord, individual and witness • 2020 Q8(c) individual and witness

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/22: The world – three levels of reality and three verdicts

THE THREE LEVELS OF REALITY (Advaita)

ULTIMATE (pāramārthika) the absolute alone; NEVER SUBLATED (trikālābādhita)
EMPIRICAL (vyāvahārika) the world, the Lord and individual selves – VALID,
coherent, PUBLIC, law-governed, INTERSUBJECTIVE;
sublated only by knowledge of the absolute

APPARENT (prātibhāsika) dream, rope-snake, shell-silver – PRIVATE, cancelled
within empirical experience itself

=> the world is denied ABSOLUTE reality, NOT empirical functioning

=> DEPENDENTLY REAL (mithyā) ≠ WHOLLY NON-EXISTENT (tuccha, e.g. a hare's horn)

=> sublation (bādhā) is what GRADES the three levels

THREE VERDICTS ON THE WORLD

ADVAITA APPARENT TRANSFORMATION (vivarta); the rope-snake substrate is
real, the appearance dependent and sublatable; mithyā not tuccha

VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA ... the world is REAL and forms the NON-CONSCIOUS (acit) dimension
of the absolute's BODY; creation is a real manifestation
involving the non-conscious mode (prakṛti); cause-state SUBTLE,
effect-state GROSS; because effects are real, the universe is a
MEANINGFUL FIELD of duty, devotion and divine manifestation

DVAITA the world is REAL; dependence does NOT cancel distinctness;
God is its EFFICIENT governor, dependent primordial matter its
MATERIAL cause; matter is NOT absorbed into identity by
knowledge => the STRONGEST realist posture among the three

ŚAṆKARA vs RĀMĀNUJA ON WORLD-STATUS – asked 2021 Q8(b), 15 marks

ISSUE	ŚAṆKARA	RĀMĀNUJA
reality of the world	mithyā, dependent appearance	real manifestation
change in the absolute	DENIED	ACCEPTED in a qualified sense, through modes
soteriology	world SUBLATED in knowledge	world MEANINGFUL in devotion
God-world relation	empirical	intrinsic BODY-SOUL relation

EVALUATIVE LINE: Śaṅkara protects ABSOLUTENESS by reducing world-status;

Rāmānuja protects WORLD-STATUS by qualifying absoluteness.

SHARED GROUND (state it first): total dependence on the absolute · no second independent principle · scripture as final authority

MADHVA ON INDIVIDUAL AND WORLD – asked 2021 Q8(c), 15 marks

both are REAL and DISTINCT from God · difference is not merely practical but METAPHYSICAL · prepares directly for FIVEFOLD DIFFERENCE (Panel 20)

! TRAP: equating mithyā with tuccha converts a graded ontology into nihilism.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/22: Apparent transformation versus real transformation

THE CAUSATION FORK – asked 2022 Q5(e), 10 marks:

"Do you agree that Vivartavāda is the logical development of Pariṇāmavāda?"

SĀṂKHYA REAL transformation (pariṇāma-vāda): the effect is a REAL MODIFICATION
of the cause MILK => CURD

ADVAITA APPARENT transformation (vivarta): the substrate is UNCHANGED and the
effect is a SUBLATABLE APPEARANCE ROPE => SNAKE

ARGUMENT FOR "logical development"

both refuse production FROM NOTHING and both make the effect CAUSE-DEPENDENT
if the cause is the ABSOLUTE, and the absolute admits NO real modification,
then the effect cannot be equally real AS TRANSFORMATION
=> transformation must be only APPARENT: not pariṇāma but vivarta
=> vivarta PRESERVES causal dependence while PREVENTING real change in the absolute

ARGUMENT AGAINST

real transformation and apparent transformation assign CONTRARY ONTOLOGICAL STATUS
to the effect
what real transformation MOST INSISTS ON – genuine change in the cause – is
precisely what apparent transformation ABANDONS
=> a doctrine that denies the core commitment of another is a REJECTION, not a
completion

GRADED VERDICT – the mark-winning line

apparent transformation DEVELOPS the search for an effect DEPENDENT on its cause,
but ABANDONS real transformation's central commitment to REAL transformation.
AGREEMENT IS STRUCTURAL; DISAGREEMENT IS ONTOLOGICAL.

FIVE-POSITION TRANSFORMATION BANK (one line each, high comparative value)

Advaita APPARENT transformation – substrate unchanged, effect sublatale
Sāṃkhya REAL transformation of primordial matter
Rāmānuja REAL transformation OF MODES; essence uncorrupted
Nimbārka REAL transformation of the absolute's DEPENDENT POWERS
Vallabha UNCHANGED REAL MANIFESTATION (avikṛta-pariṇāma) – effect real,
cause unaltered; NEITHER vivarta NOR ordinary pariṇāma

! TRAP: answering "yes" or "no" flatly. The word in the stem is DEVELOPMENT, and it
is the graded verdict that is being tested.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 13/22: Illusion, ignorance, two indescribabilities, the locus problem

TWO SENSES OF INDESCRIBABILITY – asked 2018 Q5(c), 10 marks

ULTIMATE REALITY (brahman)	INDESCRIBABLE ILLUSION (māyā)
non-dual, non-objectifiable reality EXCEEDS limiting subject-predicate description	appearance that CANNOT BE CLASSIFIED as ultimately real (it is SUBLATED) NOR as sheer non-being (it is EXPERIENCED)
does NOT mean uncertain reality	DOES mean indeterminate ontological status
the UNSUBLATED reality BECAUSE OF which description and experience are possible	a DEPENDENT and SUBLATABLE explanatory principle
=> a SURPLUS: too real to be predicated	=> an INDETERMINACY: falls BETWEEN the two ultimate ontological heads

X THE TWO USES ARE NOT IDENTICAL

! critical add-on: realist schools accept the absolute's TRANSCENDENCE far more readily than they accept an alleged THIRD ONTOLOGICAL STATUS for illusion

TWO POWERS OF ILLUSION

concealment (āvaraṇa-śakti) HIDES the absolute's true nature
projection (vikṣepa-śakti) THROWS UP the world of names and forms
=> together they explain how ignorance can both COVER and FABRICATE
=> they reappear as the TWO COMPONENTS of superimposition (Panel 16)

ILLUSION AND IGNORANCE – IDENTITY OR DISTINCTION? (? genuinely non-uniform)

? some formulations treat them as broadly INTERCHANGEABLE
? others: illusion = COSMIC / OBJECTIVE, associated with the LORD
 ignorance = INDIVIDUAL / SUBJECTIVE, associated with the INDIVIDUAL
+ both are usually regarded as INDESCRIBABLE
=> EXAM FORMULA: state the distinction carefully AND note that usage varies

IGNORANCE (avidyā) IN THE THREE SCHOOLS

ADVAITA BEGINNINGLESS (anādi) yet TERMINABLE (sānta) by knowledge; NOT
eternal as the absolute is eternal; POSITIVE IN FORM
(bhāva-rūpa), else it could not both conceal and project;
through it the self identifies with body, mind, senses,
DOERSHIP and ENJOYERSHIP => empirical existence is structured by
ignorance, NOT by a real transformation of the self
VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA ... NO indescribable cosmic principle; REAL ignorance of God's
nature and of the soul's dependence; tied to karma; removed by
right knowledge with devotion and especially SELF-SURRENDER
(prapatti)
DVAITA ignorance is REAL; not a metaphysical veil over identity;
overcome by correct knowledge, devotion and divine GRACE
=> Madhva's realism preserves stronger continuity between
ignorance, ethics, devotion and salvation

THE LOCUS-AND-OBJECT PROBLEM (āśraya / viśaya)

whose is ignorance?
in the INDIVIDUAL => CIRCULAR, since the individual arises WITHIN ignorance
in the ABSOLUTE => the absolute appears COMPROMISED
=> the doorway to Rāmānuja's seven objections (Panels 14-15)

! TRAP: flattening illusion and ignorance into a synonym-pair, OR asserting the distinction as universal. State it, then record the variation.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 14/22: The seven objections, part one – locus to indefinability

RĀMĀNUJA'S SEVENFOLD CHARGE (sapta-anupapatti / sapta-vidhā-anupapatti)

asked 2025 Q5(d), 10 marks · names and sequence VARY slightly across expositions

1 LOCUS (āśraya-anupapatti) – untenable locus of ignorance

OBJ in the absolute => it ceases to be pure consciousness;
in the individual => the individual is itself a PRODUCT of ignorance
=> MUTUAL DEPENDENCE (anyonyāśraya)
REPLY ... VIVARAṆA: the absolute is the LOCUS (āśraya) WITHOUT being modified or
tainted, since ignorance is not a real modification of it
REPLY ... BHĀMATĪ: ignorance is located in the individual, and the
individual-ignorance relation is BEGINNINGLESS (anāditva); a
beginningless seed-sprout dependence is not automatically vicious
RESIDUE . THE HARDEST OBJECTION: two Advaita sub-schools give TWO DIFFERENT
answers, which is itself a dialectical opening

2 CONCEALMENT (tirodhāna-anupapatti)

OBJ the absolute is SELF-LUMINOUS (svayaṃ-prakāśa); to conceal it is to
destroy its very nature as light / consciousness
REPLY ... ignorance does not conceal the absolute AS SUCH; it conceals it AS
RECOGNISED BY the individual, and the concealment is itself only
apparent from the standpoint of ignorance
EXAMPLE . a CLOUD does not extinguish the SUN; it obstructs the VIEWER'S vision
RESIDUE . the analogy helps against literal concealment, but one may still ask
how ANY obstruction arises when the absolute alone is ultimately real

3 NATURE (svarūpa-anupapatti)

OBJ the nature of ignorance is incoherent if it is NEITHER real NOR unreal
REPLY ... the being / non-being / indescribable TRICHOTOMY: experienced => not
non-being; sublated => not being; therefore INDESCRIBABLE
RESIDUE . works ONLY if SUBLATABILITY is accepted as a criterion of degrees of
reality – which realist schools DENY OUTRIGHT

4 INDEFINABILITY (anirvacanīyatva-anupapatti)

OBJ whatever exists must be real or unreal; a THIRD CATEGORY is a refusal
to answer, and seems to violate the excluded middle
REPLY ... the contrast is NOT being versus non-being as bare contradictories but
ONTOLOGICAL GRADES measured by sublatability; and the claim is not that
illusion lacks a determinate nature altogether, only that it cannot be
filed under EITHER ultimate head
REPLY ... TU QUOQUE: Rāmānuja's NON-CONSCIOUS (acit), real-but-dependent BODY of
the absolute, ALSO occupies a status that is neither independent
absolutism nor non-being
RESIDUE . Rāmānuja and Madhva call this VERBAL unless the third grade is
INDEPENDENTLY GROUNDED by a means of valid knowledge

5 MEANS OF KNOWING (pramāṇa-anupapatti)

OBJ perception gives an OBJECT, not a positive ignorance; inference lacks a valid mark; scripture does not straightforwardly teach a POSITIVE INDEFINABLE ENTITY

REPLY ... WITNESS-PERCEPTION (sākṣi-pratyakṣa): the immediate experience "I DO NOT KNOW" presents ignorance POSITIVELY, not as blank absence

REPLY ... POSTULATION (arthāpatti): if knowledge REMOVES bondage, there must be something POSITIVE to remove

REPLY ... scripture itself teaches illusion / ignorance as a DEPENDENT POWER responsible for appearance

RESIDUE . Rāmānuja: "I do not know" reports an ABSENCE of knowledge, not a mysterious positive entity => with (1), THE MOST DANGEROUS OBJECTION

6 REMOVER (nivartaka-anupapatti)

OBJ what KIND of knowledge removes ignorance? Qualityless knowledge seems CONTENTLESS; determinate knowledge is itself WITHIN ignorance

REPLY ... UNDIVIDED-FORM MENTAL MODE (akhaṇḍākāra-vṛtti): the great-sentence-generated cognition that takes the absolute as content by SUBLATING all limiting adjuncts

REPLY ... knowledge does NOT act on ignorance as one object acts on another; TRUE cognition SUBLATES the false, then the mental mode SUBSIDES like the stick consumed in the fire it stirs

RESIDUE . strong inside Advaita's LADDER-MODEL; a critic still asks how a mental mode WITHIN the empirical order can TERMINATE that order

! ATTRIBUTION: the undivided-form mental mode is a LATER systematic explanation; do not present it as Śaṅkara's verbatim formula

7 CESSATION (nivṛtti-anupapatti)

OBJ if ignorance is REAL it cannot be removed; if UNREAL there is nothing to remove; and if removed, the status of its CESSATION is obscure

REPLY ... cessation is NOT a fifth entity produced after ignorance; it is simply the absolute REMAINING AS IT ALWAYS WAS once superimposition is sublated

EXAMPLE . asking where ignorance WENT is like asking where the SNAKE went when the ROPE was recognised

RESIDUE . elegant IF superimposition is granted; QUESTION-BEGGING if the opponent rejects the rope-snake model for world-experience

FORCE OF THE SEVEN – three levels of attack

(a) the STATUS of ignorance

(b) the POSSIBILITY of concealment and projection

(c) the COHERENCE of liberation as removal of ignorance

=> Advaita answers MOST convincingly where SUBLATION-LOGIC applies – CESSATION and CONCEALMENT; it is MOST VULNERABLE on LOCUS and MEANS OF KNOWING, because the locus and proof of ignorance are not settled without granting Advaita's own standpoint

=> the seven are NOT a list; they are a systematic attack on the EXPLANATORY COST of making the world indescribable

RĀMĀNUJA'S POSITIVE ALTERNATIVE – what replaces illusion-doctrine

INSEPARABLE DEPENDENCE (aprthaksiddhi) ... conscious (cit) and non-conscious (acit) are INSEPARABLE from the absolute yet REALLY DISTINCT as MODES

BODY-SOUL RELATION (śarīra-śarīrī-bhāva) ... world and selves are the absolute's BODY; the absolute is their INDWELLING CONTROLLER

ERROR-THEORY: APPREHENSION OF THE REAL (satkhyāti) ... cognition is ALWAYS of the real; error is mistaking ONE REAL FOR ANOTHER

MECHANISM: ELEMENTAL INTERMIXTURE (pañcikaṛaṇa / trivṛtkaraṇa) – every object contains a portion of every element, so a REAL silver-element in the shell can be misapprehended

ADVAITA'S POSITION

does NOT accept illusion in the Advaita sense of ontological illusion; the world is REAL and ignorance is REAL ignorance

error = APPREHENSION OTHERWISE, NEWLY ANALYSED (abhinava-anyathā-khyāti)

Madhva's critique is SHARPER in one respect: it does not try to absorb plurality into qualified unity but makes REAL DIFFERENCE FUNDAMENTAL

THE 2018 PRINTED ANOMALY – Q7(c), 15 marks

the paper asks how Rāmānuja REFUTES illusion AND why illusion is "NEEDED BY BOTH". The second sentence is philosophically unusual and is RETAINED AS PRINTED.

ROUTE: FLAG the anomaly · state that Rāmānuja REJECTS Advaitic illusion · read the demand as comparing HOW EACH SYSTEM EXPLAINS PLURALITY – Śaṅkara by a sublatability

indescribable power, Rāmānuja by REAL INSEPARABLE MODES.

! do NOT rationalise it into a false doctrine; do NOT skip the printed demand.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 16/22: Superimposition, the four error-theories, the ledger

SUPERIMPOSITION (adhyāsa) – Śaṅkara's opening move
definition ... MUTUAL superimposition of subject and object
shorthand ATASMIN TAD-BUDDHIḤ – cognition of one thing in what is NOT that
fuller attributes of the OBJECT put on the SUBJECT, and vice versa
character NATURAL (naisargika) and BEGINNINGLESS (anādi)
=> ordinary life is ALREADY structured by misidentification BEFORE
any philosophical reflection
components ... CONCEALMENT (āvaraṇa) hides the true nature .
PROJECTION (vikṣepa) throws up the false appearance
(mirrors the two powers of illusion – Panel 13)
root of all empirical dealing (vyavahāra):
"I am tall" . "I am happy" . "I act" . "I know"
=> bodily and mental predicates FALSELY ATTRIBUTED to the self, and consciousness
falsely attributed to body and mind
=> worldly experience is not OCCASIONALLY mistaken; it is STRUCTURALLY pervaded
examples ROPE-SNAKE . SHELL-SILVER . DESERT-MIRAGE
PROCESS vs STATUS: superimposition is the PROCESS; indescribable-error theory
states the STATUS of the object thereby presented => CONNECT, never CONFUSE
comparative force: for NYĀYA error is wrong cognition OF OBJECTS; for ADVAITA the
EGOIC STANDPOINT ITSELF is already infected by primordial superimposition

THE PROBLEM OF ERROR – asked 2021 Q7(a), 20 marks, "critically discuss"

NYĀYA	APPREHENSION OTHERWISE (anyathā-khyāti): the silver is REAL
ADVAITA REFUTES	silver known ELSEWHERE, wrongly connected with this locus
	sublation takes the form "THIS IS A SHELL" and cancels the
	silver AT THAT VERY LOCUS; it does NOT relocate it. Had it
	been real silver merely misconnected, correction would
	dissolve a RELATION, not annihilate OBJECTHOOD so radically.
	Also, the illusory silver is PRACTICALLY EFFECTIVE – one
VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA	reaches for it – which a bare memory-image should not be.
	APPREHENSION OF THE REAL (satkhyāti) + elemental
BUDDHIST	intermixture supplies a REAL silver-element in the shell
	APPREHENSION OF THE NON-EXISTENT (asat-khyāti) – REJECTED:
	the illusory silver APPEARS, and sheer non-being cannot
ADVAITA	INDESCRIBABLE-ERROR THEORY (anirvacanīya-khyāti):
	REAL? then it would survive sublation – it does not
	UNREAL? then it could never appear – but it did
	=> dependent, provisional, INDESCRIBABLE status

PRESUPPOSITION-LED DEFENCE OF INDESCRIBABILITY – the 20-mark spine

P1 .. being (sat) / non-being (asat) / indescribable are EXHAUSTIVE and MUTUALLY
EXCLUSIVE grades within Advaita's scheme
D .. sat = NEVER SUBLATED (trikālābhāta) . asat = NEVER PRESENTED at all
(hare's horn, square circle) . anirvacanīya = PRESENTED, then SUBLATED
A .. illusion and world fall in the THIRD grade
P2 .. SUBLATION (bādhā) is the criterion of degrees of reality
A .. without bādhā the three-tier scheme COLLAPSES into realism or nihilism
P3 .. experience of an object gives it SOME positive status
A .. hence Advaita prefers indescribable-error theory over asat-khyāti
P4 .. ignorance is POSITIVE IN FORM (bhāva-rūpa), not merely privative
A .. a bare absence could not perform BOTH concealment AND projection
OBJ . "indescribable" seems to violate the excluded middle
REP . the trichotomy is GRADES of sublatability, not bare contradictories
RES . Rāmānuja and Madhva call it VERBAL unless the third grade is independently
established
NOTE ŚRĪHARṢA's strategy in the Khaṇḍanakhaṇḍakhādyā is DIALECTICAL, not
constructive: he refuses a positive definition of the real and shows that
the opponent's definitions FAIL

CRITICAL LIMIT: the refutation establishes an ANOMALY for Nyāya rather than a PROOF
of the third grade – the Naiyāyika can reply that cancellation removes only the
WRONG CONNECTION.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 17/22: The great sentence "that thou art"

TAT TVAM ASI – "THAT THOU ART"
asked 2023 Q5(c), 10 marks

TAT ("that")	TVAM ("thou")
DIRECT MEANING (vācyārtha) the LORD (īśvara) associated with illusion: OMNISCIENT · REMOTE · COSMIC CAUSE · LORDSHIP	DIRECT MEANING (vācyārtha) the INDIVIDUAL (jīva) associated with ignorance and limitation: FINITE · IMMEDIATE · AGENT · IGNORANT
IMPLIED MEANING (lakṣyārtha) PURE CONSCIOUSNESS	IMPLIED MEANING (lakṣyārtha) PURE CONSCIOUSNESS

the DIRECT meanings CONFLICT: omniscience, lordship and cosmic causality cannot literally be identical with finitude, ignorance and empirical agency

PART-ABANDONING IMPLICATION (bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā)
= ABANDONING-AND-RETAINING IMPLICATION (jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā)
► ABANDON the incompatible portions of BOTH direct meanings
► RETAIN the COMMON IMPLIED MEANING

IDENTITY AT THE LEVEL OF ESSENCE, not crude sameness of empirical conditions

THE CANONICAL PARALLEL

so'yaṃ devadattaḥ – "THIS is THAT Devadatta"
drop: then / there / youth drop: now / here / age
keep: THE IDENTICAL PERSON
=> likewise the Lord-individual contradiction is resolved by dropping ADJUNCTS (upādhi) and retaining underlying CONSCIOUSNESS
=> implication (lakṣaṇā) is a RECOGNISED semantic operation; Advaita claims only that THIS sentence needs the MIXED variety – neither total abandonment (jahal-lakṣaṇā) nor total retention (ajahal-lakṣaṇā)

THE FOUR STANDARD GREAT SENTENCES (name one; do not recite the list)

tat tvam asi · ahaṃ brahmāsmi · prajñānaṃ brahma · ayam ātmā brahma

RIVAL READINGS

VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA and DVAITA REJECT the identity-reading; for them the great sentences indicate DEPENDENCE, PARTICIPATION or SPECIAL RELATION
for Rāmānuja "thou" names a self whose very nature is to be an INSEPARABLE MODE of "that" => the sentence asserts INSEPARABILITY, not sameness
=> the interpretation of ONE SENTENCE becomes the battleground for the WHOLE architecture of Vedānta

! TEXTUAL CAUTION – high value, frequently missed

distinguish an UPANIṢADIC GREAT SENTENCE from a later DOCTRINAL SLOGAN.
"Brahma satyaṃ jagan-mithyā, jīvo brahmaiva nāparaḥ" – used in the printed 2022 question – is a TRADITIONAL ADVAITA SUMMARY, NOT one of the four standard Upaniṣadic great sentences. Quote it as a summary verse and SAY SO.

ADVAITA – liberation as RECOGNITION – asked 2023 Q7(b), 15 marks
 definition ... PRĀPTASYA PRĀPTIḤ – attainment of what is ALREADY ATTAINED
 because the self is ALWAYS the absolute; bondage is IGNORANCE ALONE
 therefore liberation is simply REMOVAL of ignorance through knowledge
 images a NECKLACE already hanging round one's own neck · the ROPE-SNAKE
 correction in which NOTHING is created or destroyed
 argument if liberation were PRODUCED it would be an EFFECT, and every effect
 is impermanent => liberation would be TEMPORARY
 ONLY KNOWLEDGE LIBERATES
 action (karma) and worship (upāsana) PURIFY but do not DIRECTLY produce
 liberation => rejection of JÑĀNA-KARMA-SAMUCCAYA-VĀDA
 FOURFOLD QUALIFICATION (sādhana-catuṣṭaya)
 1 discrimination (viveka) – eternal vs non-eternal
 2 detachment (vairāgya)
 3 sixfold discipline (ṣaṭ-sampatti)
 4 desire for liberation (mumukṣutva)
 FROM PREPARATION TO STABLE KNOWLEDGE
 HEARING (śravaṇa) establishes the intended non-dual teaching under a
 competent teacher
 REFLECTION (manana) removes intellectual doubt; tests against contrary
 reasoning
 CONTEMPLATION (nididhyāsana) removes entrenched contrary habits of identification
 pedagogy: SUPERIMPOSITION AND RESCISSION (adhyāropa-apavāda) – provisional
 distinctions first employed for instruction, then WITHDRAWN
 LIBERATION WHILE LIVING (jīvanmukti)
 the body continues by COMMENCED KARMA (prārabdha) – an ARROW ALREADY RELEASED
 DISEMBODIED LIBERATION (videhamukti) adds NO NEW liberation
 no new binding karma accrues because DOERSHIP has been dissolved

VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA – liberation as COMMUNION
 recovery of the self's UNOBSTRUCTED nature, LIKENESS to God, eternal loving
 communion and service WITHOUT numerical identity; the liberated self remains REAL
 and DISTINCT
 disinterested action and scriptural knowledge PREPARE; contemplation matures as
 DEVOTION (bhakti); SELF-SURRENDER (prapatti / śaraṇāgati) is the INCLUSIVE route;
 GRACE (prasāda) is indispensable
 karmic obstruction ENDS; ATTRIBUTIVE CONSCIOUSNESS (dharma-bhūta-jñāna) becomes
 UNRESTRICTED
 X NO Advaitic liberation-while-living in the strict sense: embodiment remains a
 condition of bondage

DVAITA – liberation as SERVICE – asked 2022 Q8(c), 15 marks
 eternal blissful SERVICE of Viṣṇu in Vaikuṇṭha; right knowledge of his supremacy,
 devotion and GRACE indispensable; difference NEVER abolished
 GRADATION (tāratamya): released souls do NOT enjoy identical bliss or rank
 standard sources also classify some bound souls as eternal transmigrators or
 darkness-eligible – doctrinally supportable, PHILOSOPHICALLY CONTESTED

MADHVA vs RĀMĀNUJA – the 2022 comparison

ISSUE	RĀMĀNUJA	MADHVA
shared theistic ground	real God, soul, world; devotion + grace	real God, soul, world; devotion + grace
God-self relation	inseparable MODE / BODY of the absolute	DISTINCT dependent substance, NOT God's body
liberated individuality	retained in communion and service	retained in ETERNAL DIFFERENCE and service
knowledge and bliss	obstruction removed; attributive knowledge unrestricted	degree follows a REAL HIERARCHY
equality of the liberated	alike in essential type; NO intrinsic gradation	retain GRADATION (tāratamya)
causal background	efficient AND material cause through real modes	God efficient; primordial matter material

! the highest-scoring conclusion is NOT "both are devotional". Rāmānuja resolves
 plurality through INSEPARABLE QUALIFICATION; Madhva treats QUALITATIVE
 DIFFERENCE AND HIERARCHY as permanent even in liberation.

! costs differ too: DIVINE SIMPLICITY for Rāmānuja, MORAL UNIVERSALITY for Madhva.

ONE-LINE SYNTHESIS

non-dual ontology liberation as RECOGNITION

qualified non-dual ontology .. liberation as COMMUNION

dualist ontology liberation as SERVICE

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 19/22: Inseparable dependence and the body-soul relation

THE PROBLEM RĀMĀNUJA IS SOLVING

ADVAITA unity real, plurality appearance => world and devotion downgraded
DVAITA plurality real, unity only dependence => non-dual sentences strained
RĀMĀNUJA ... can plurality be REAL and yet INSIDE unity?

INSEPARABLE DEPENDENCE (aprthaksiddhi)

conscious selves (cit) + non-conscious matter (acit)
▶ exist in an INSEPARABLE relation with ultimate reality
▶ CANNOT exist or be conceived INDEPENDENTLY of it
▶ are NOT IDENTICAL with it
=> the central conceptual instrument by which qualified non-dualism combines UNITY and PLURALITY

INSEPARABLE QUALIFIER (aprthaksiddha-viśeṣaṇa)

a qualifier that CANNOT STAND APART from the substance it qualifies
the attribute is REAL and DISTINCT – but INSEPARABLE
STRONGER than a mere conceptual relation • WEAKER than identity
! a MODE is not a PART: parts can be separated, modes cannot

BODY-SOUL RELATION (śarīra-śarīrī-bhāva) – asked 2024 Q5(e), 10 marks

selves and world = the absolute's BODY (śarīra)
the absolute = their indwelling SOUL (śarīrin / antaryāmin)
THREE CONDITIONS OF BEING A BODY – state ALL THREE; this is the answer's spine
1 entirely SUPPORTED by it
2 entirely CONTROLLED by it
3 exists FOR ITS PURPOSES
! "body" is FUNCTIONAL, not physical: whatever is SUPPORTED, CONTROLLED and USED by an indwelling self – which is why CONSCIOUS SELVES can also be called God's body
! THE ANALOGY IS ASYMMETRIC: an ordinary self is AFFECTED, limited and pained by its body's defects; God's essential auspicious nature is UNTOUCHED. The parallel holds for SUPPORT-CONTROL-PURPOSE and FAILS for VULNERABILITY.
=> this asymmetry is how "critically discuss" is answered in 2024

WHAT THE DOCTRINE BUYS

preserves NON-DUALITY there is only ONE ultimate substantive whole
preserves REAL DIFFERENCE .. cit and acit are GENUINE MODES, not illusory
preserves DEVOTION the God-soul relation remains MEANINGFUL
=> in one stroke it answers Advaita's MONISM and Dvaita's PLURALISM

MADHVA'S REPLY

calling souls God's BODY already concedes too much: a body is an INSTRUMENT of its soul, and a REAL self cannot be another self's instrument without loss of its own substantiality => Madhva keeps DEPENDENCE and DROPS the body-relation

FORMULA FOR QUICK RECALL

Advaita IDENTITY without real plurality
Viśiṣṭādvaita ... INSEPARABLE PLURALITY within unity
Dvaita ETERNAL PLURALITY with dependence

! MAJOR TRAP: aprthaksiddhi is NOT identity. Do not paraphrase it as "a kind of oneness"; that silently converts an inseparable qualifier into an identity.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 20/22: Fivefold difference and Dvaita's realism

FIVEFOLD DIFFERENCE (pañcavidhabheda) – asked 2020 Q5(d), 10 marks

NOT practical distinctions generated by ignorance – METAPHYSICALLY ULTIMATE

- 1 jīva-īśvara-bheda soul vs God
- 2 jīva-jīva-bheda soul vs soul
- 3 jīva-jaḍa-bheda soul vs matter
- 4 īśvara-jaḍa-bheda God vs matter
- 5 jaḍa-jaḍa-bheda matter vs matter

WHAT THE DOCTRINE DOES

- + directly REJECTS Advaita's claim of IDENTITY
- + ALSO rejects Rāmānuja's attempt to retain unity through QUALIFIED INSEPARABILITY
- + difference is NEITHER epistemic NOR merely empirical: it is REAL and ETERNAL

CONSEQUENCES – where "significance" answers separate from list answers

from (1) ... the soul remains ETERNALLY DIFFERENT from God => DEVOTION IS NEVER TRANSCENDED; it is the PERMANENT FORM of the relation

from (2) ... soul-soul difference is real => HIERARCHY AMONG SOULS IS POSSIBLE
=> gradation (tāratamya) in liberation, and the severe classifications of bound souls

from (5) ... matter-matter difference is real => the PLURAL WORLD IS ONTOLOGICALLY ROBUST; no reduction to one substance

overall God alone INDEPENDENT (svatantra); everything else DEPENDENT (paratantra) – difference does NOT threaten supremacy, because supremacy is defined by INDEPENDENCE, not by ABSORPTION

SUPPORTING APPARATUS

? UNIQUE DIFFERENTIATOR (viśeṣa) – invoked so that real distinctions, e.g. between a substance and its attribute, can be secured WITHOUT requiring a further difference AD INFINITUM. Commonly presented this way; EXPOSITIONS VARY. Without some such device Dvaita faces a REGRESS problem.

WITNESS (sākṣin) – the ultimate internal validator of cognition, which for Madhva CONFIRMS real difference rather than dissolving it
! same word as Advaita's witness, OPPOSED metaphysics

CRITICISM AND REPLY

OBJ eternal difference risks ULTIMATE PLURALISM and a hierarchy that offends MORAL UNIVERSALITY; and non-dual Upaniṣadic sentences become harder to read

REPLY ... plurality is NOT a defect; it is reality AS CREATED AND SUSTAINED BY GOD, and devotion is STRONGEST when ontological distinction is preserved

RESIDUE . the GRADED DESTINY of souls remains the sharpest normative difficulty and should be EVALUATED, not reported casually

! TRAP: reducing the doctrine to "difference between God and world" – that much is compatible with qualified non-dualism and proves nothing distinctive.

NIMBĀRKA – DUALISTIC NON-DUALISM (dvaitādvaita) · matter asked 2020 Q5(e), 10 marks

God, conscious selves (cit) and non-conscious reality (acit) are ALL REAL
 selves and matter DIFFER from the absolute because they are LIMITED
 selves and matter are NON-DIFFERENT because they have NO INDEPENDENT EXISTENCE
 => difference and non-difference are EQUALLY REAL ASPECTS OF ONE RELATION
 NON-CONSCIOUS REALITY (acit) – the three types demanded in 2020:
 1 ordinary primordial matter (prākṛta) material nature and its products
 2 non-prakṛtic divine substance (aprākṛta) substance associated with the
 divine realm / body
 3 time (kāla)
 ? terminology and the PLACEMENT OF TIME vary across expositions => STATE the
 classification adopted; do NOT invent further subtypes
 matter is NEITHER illusion NOR an independent second absolute: REAL ·
 TRANSFORMABLE · DEPENDENT – related to the absolute as POWER/ATTRIBUTE to POSSESSOR
 creation is a REAL TRANSFORMATION of the absolute's DEPENDENT POWERS
 liberation: knowledge enabled by devotion and grace, WITHOUT destroying
 individuality

VALLABHA – PURE NON-DUALISM (śuddhādvaita)

the supreme is Kṛṣṇa; souls and world are REAL MANIFESTATIONS, not products of an
 indefinable illusion
 UNCHANGED REAL MANIFESTATION (avikṛta-pariṇāma): NEITHER merely apparent
 transformation NOR an ordinary transformation that ALTERS the absolute – the
 EFFECT IS REAL while the absolute remains UNCHANGED
 the world remains a DIVINE MANIFESTATION; the cycle of possessive bondage
 (saṃsāra) arises from ignorance and EGOIC IDENTIFICATION
 PATH OF GRACE (puṣṭi-mārga): grace, loving devotion and service are CENTRAL, not
 provisional aids to identity-knowledge
 ! liberation = PARTICIPATION in Kṛṣṇa's bliss and loving service. Do NOT describe
 it as the disappearance of the real world or as loss of individuality.
 ! COST: "real effect from an unaltered cause" needs its own account of how
 MANIFESTATION differs from MODIFICATION – the position is named clearly and the
 mechanism is more asserted than argued

CAITANYA TRADITION – INCONCEIVABLE DIFFERENCE-NON-DIFFERENCE (acintyabhedābheda)

Kṛṣṇa, souls and world are REALLY NON-DIFFERENT as dependent divine powers and
 REALLY DIFFERENT as distinct manifestations
 "INCONCEIVABLE" (acintya) marks the inability of FINITE REASONING to reduce the
 relation to identity alone or difference alone
 ! it is NOT permission for contradiction without doctrine
 souls remain ATOMIC, REAL and DEPENDENT; the world is a real manifestation of
 divine EXTERNAL POWER, not an illusion
 LOVING DEVOTION (bhakti / prema) is the SOLE DIRECT PATH

FOUR-SCHOOL LIBERATION MATRIX – asked 2018 Q7(a), 20 marks

SCHOOL	METAPHYSICAL RELATION	DIRECT PATH	LIBERATED CONDITION
qualified non-dualism	real inseparable mode / body of the absolute	devotion or surrender with grace	unobstructed knowledge, bliss, communion, service WITHOUT identity
dualism	distinct dependent reality	knowledge, devotion, grace	eternal service, GRADED bliss, permanent difference
pure non-dualism	real UNCHANGED manifestations of Kṛṣṇa	grace-nourished loving devotion	participation in divine bliss and loving service; world NOT sublated
inconceivable difference-non-difference	simultaneously dependent non-difference AND real difference	loving devotion culminating in divine love	eternal loving relation; INDIVIDUALITY REMAINS

COMMON GROUND theistic devotion and grace

DECISIVE DIFFERENCE whether the soul is an INSEPARABLE MODE, an ETERNALLY
 DISTINCT DEPENDENT, a REAL UNCHANGED MANIFESTATION, or an
 INCONCEIVABLY DIFFERENT-NON-DIFFERENT POWER

! never collapse this into "all four are devotional"

ŚAṂKARA AGAINST SĀṂKHYA – THE CHIEF-WRESTLER (pradhāna-malla) DEBATE

WHY THE NEAREST RIVAL IS THE MOST DANGEROUS

- + accepts EFFECT-PRE-EXISTENT-IN-CAUSE (satkāryavāda), as Advaita broadly does in transformed fashion
- + posits a SINGLE material principle (prakṛti / pradhāna)
- + makes liberation turn on DISCRIMINATIVE KNOWLEDGE, not ritual
- BUT makes that principle UNCONSCIOUS

FOUR ARGUMENTS

- 1 THE CAUSE MUST BE CONSCIOUS – the Upaniṣads describe the world-cause as being (sat), KNOWING, WILLING and PURPOSIVE; an unconscious principle cannot satisfy those descriptions
- 2 TELEOLOGY REQUIRES INTELLIGENCE – mere equilibrium and disturbance of the constituents (guṇa) do not explain MEANINGFUL ORDERED creation
- 3 THE WITNESS-MATTER RELATION IS UNINTELLIGIBLE – how does the mere PROXIMITY of an inactive conscious subject (puruṣa) set unconscious matter into purposive motion?
- 4 THE UPANIṢADIC CAUSE IS ONE, NOT DUAL – Sāṃkhya divides the ultimate, so it cannot claim full scriptural support

SĀṢKHYA'S REPLY (state it in a 15/20-marker)

scriptural appeal is INTERNAL to Vedānta · purposiveness is the CONSTITUTIONAL TENDENCY of matter towards the subject's experience and release · proximity-causation is no more obscure than an UNCHANGING absolute grounding a world it does not enter

! OWNERSHIP: the 2018 Q7(b) question on the Advaita reaction to real transformation is PRIMARY-OWNED BY SĀṢKHYA; Vedānta supplies only the Advaita side

FIVE CONSEQUENCES OF NON-DUAL ABSOLUTISM – asked 2019 Q8(a), 20 marks

THESIS: the absolute ALONE is ultimately real

- 1 WORLD REDUCED TO APPEARANCE dependently real (mithyā), sublatale; NOT wholly non-existent
- 2 INDIVIDUALITY AND AGENCY BECOME PROVISIONAL ... moral agency AFFIRMED empirically, DENIED ultimacy
- 3 ETHICS AND KARMA BECOME EMPIRICAL duty, merit, sin, karmic causality remain VALID but NOT FINAL => charge of downgrading
- 4 DEVOTION BECOMES PREPARATORY if the Lord is empirical, devotion is PEDAGOGIC, not final consummation
- 5 INSTRUMENTS ARE EMPIRICALLY VALID ONLY ... perception, inference and even scripture are transcended on realisation

SELF-REFERENTIAL TENSION – where 20-mark answers are won
 Is Advaita SELF-DEFEATING, relying on reason and scripture only to subordinate them? Or is this a LADDER-MODEL in which means are valid until the highest insight dawns? (clearing-nut · stick consumed in the pyre)
 => self-cancellation is ORDERLY because it COINCIDES with the removal of the ignorance that made the instrument necessary

BALANCED ASSESSMENT: absolutism purchases METAPHYSICAL PURITY at the cost of reclassifying ordinary life as LOWER TRUTH – the highest wisdom to admirers, ontological austerity bought by practical instability to critics.

DEFENSIVE REPLY: nothing is ABOLISHED, only RECLASSIFIED.

CRITICISM BANK WITH REPLIES (reusable in every evaluative paragraph)

qualityless absolute unknowable not known as an OBJECT; SELF-REVEALED as the ground of knowing
 illusion self-contradictory empirical contradiction belongs to the level generated WITHIN ignorance
 ethics collapses binding at the empirical level; RESIDUE: ultimate sublation still weakens moral realism
 bondage inexplicable if self IS the bondage is ignorance-born SUPERIMPOSITION;
 absolute RESIDUE: relocates rather than solves
 real modes compromise absoluteness ... qualifications express PLENITUDE; a qualified whole is absolute if NOTHING lies outside it
 eternal difference risks pluralism ... plurality is CREATED REALITY, not defect; devotion strongest when distinction preserved

CRYPTO-BUDDHIST CHARGE (pracchanna-bauddha)

FAILS as identification: the absolute is POSITIVE and SELF-LUMINOUS, unlike emptiness as ABSENCE OF OWN-BEING; and Advaita ACCEPTS scripture; Śaṅkara REFUTES consciousness-only doctrine in the Brahma-sūtra-bhāṣya
 SUCCEEDS as pressure: the shared denial of ULTIMATE world-reality remains a polemical pressure-point
 => ADVAITA IS NOT SUBJECTIVE IDEALISM: the world is not "my idea", it has empirical objectivity and is INTERSUBJECTIVE

GRADED VERDICT BANK – memorise these three

ADVAITA STRONG: most rigorous account of non-duality, self-luminosity, sublation, liberation as recognition not production
 WEAK: world, individuality, ethics and devotion become lower-order
 ? CONTESTED: the LOCUS and PROOF of ignorance
 VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA ... STRONG: divine personality, real world, real selves, devotion and scriptural theism preserved through inseparable dependence
 WEAK: real modes press on divine simplicity and changelessness
 ? CONTESTED: whether qualification enriches or limits absoluteness
 DVAITA STRONG: clearest realist basis for devotion, moral responsibility and a permanent God-soul relation
 WEAK: eternal difference risks ultimate pluralism; non-dual sentences harder to interpret
 ? CONTESTED: hierarchy among souls; the unique differentiator

READY COMPARATIVE CLOSES BY MARKS

- 10 ... Advaita SUBLATES plurality, Viśiṣṭādvaita QUALIFIES unity, Dvaita ABSOLUTISES difference.
- 15 ... Śaṅkara strongest on METAPHYSICAL UNITY, Rāmānuja on RELIGIOUS REALISM, Madhva on DEVOTIONAL DIFFERENCE; judge them by their DIFFERENT CRITERIA OF REALITY.
- 20 ... a three-way contest between SUBLATION, INSEPARABILITY and REAL DIFFERENCE as

rival ways of preserving the absolute, world, self and liberation.

TWENTY-QUESTION ROUTING GRID (2018-2025, all primary-owned)

2018 Q5(c)	10	... two indescribabilities	Panels 13
2018 Q7(a)	20	... liberation in four schools	Panels 18, 21
2018 Q7(c)	15	... refutation of illusion + printed anomaly	Panels 14, 15, 19
2019 Q8(a)	20	... consequences of absolutism	Panel 22
2020 Q5(d)	10	... significance of fivefold difference	Panel 20
2020 Q5(e)	10	... Nimbārka on matter	Panel 21
2020 Q8(c)	15	... individual and witness	Panels 9, 10
2021 Q7(a)	20	... indescribable-error theory	Panel 16
2021 Q8(b)	15	... Śaṅkara vs Rāmānuja on the world	Panel 11
2021 Q8(c)	15	... individual and world in Madhva	Panels 10, 11, 20
2022 Q5(e)	10	... apparent vs real transformation	Panel 12
2022 Q8(a)	20	... Lord, individual, witness	Panels 7, 8, 9
2022 Q8(c)	15	... Madhva vs Rāmānuja on liberation	Panel 18
2023 Q5(c)	10	... the great sentence	Panel 17
2023 Q6(a)	20	... Rāmānuja on Brahman and Īśvara	Panels 3, 7
2023 Q7(b)	15	... already-attained liberation	Panel 18
2024 Q5(e)	10	... body-soul parallel	Panel 19
2025 Q5(d)	10	... seven objections	Panels 14, 15
2025 Q6(b)	15	... efficient and material cause	Panels 4, 12
2025 Q8(a)	20	... original-reflection + soteriology	Panel 8

ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

- 10 MARKS ... define in ONE crisp sentence · place the school · 3-5 doctrinal points with one technical term · ONE rival contrast line · ONE evaluative conclusion
- 15 MARKS ... intro naming the issue and schools · doctrine in the primary thinker · conceptual mechanism · contrast with ONE rival · assessment · conclusion returning to the syllabus term
- 20 MARKS ... frame the central metaphysical issue · primary doctrine in detail · internal distinctions and models · criticism from a rival · reply and evaluative defence · implications for world, self, God, liberation · balanced judgement with ONE comparative line

DIRECTIVE DECODER

- Discuss define · mechanism · example · one rival contrast · balanced
- Examine thesis · presuppositions · internal logic · coherence verdict
- Critically examine .. siddhānta · NAMED pūrvapakṣa · reply · GRADED verdict
- Analyse break into absolute / self / world / instrument / liberation
- Evaluate explanatory gain vs unresolved tension: "strong in, weak in"
- Compare table or paired paragraphs; close with identity / qualification / difference
- Distinguish definition · locus · example · consequence for EACH term
- Elucidate explain THROUGH the example; end by linking to liberation
- Comment doctrine · one objection · one defence · sharp judgement
- Bring out derive consequences using "therefore" language
- Do you agree? partial agreement · reasons · qualification through a rival

FINAL TRAP LIST

- 1 mithyā is NOT tuccha
- 2 nirguṇa is NOT blankness
- 3 Rāmānuja does NOT accept a qualityless level
- 4 apr̥thaksiddhi is NOT identity
- 5 fivefold difference is FIVE, not "God and world"
- 6 illusion and ignorance are not simply identical – state the distinction and the variation
- 7 Madhva's liberated souls are NOT equal – gradation is doctrinal
- 8 liberation-while-living is ADVAITA's, not the realist theisms'
- 9 "Brahma satyaṃ jagan-mithyā" is a SUMMARY VERSE, not a great sentence
- 10 Madhva makes God the EFFICIENT cause only
- 11 the 2018 "Māyā needed by both" sentence is a printed ANOMALY – flag it
- 12 Advaita is NOT subjective idealism